

ENGLISH LANGUAGE PAPER 4

PART A Group Interaction

This blog post appeared on the author's personal webpage:

Time in different cultures

If you live in Hong Kong, you may well be always looking at the clock and writing down your many appointments in a calendar. But does every culture use time this way? Different cultures have different views on how to use time. For example, in Switzerland or Germany, punctuality is important. Being late is unacceptable and often viewed as disrespectful. Other cultures, on the other hand, don't stress punctuality. They might be an hour late, a day late, a week late. And that's okay. Time is not ruled by a schedule, and neither is business.



Psychologist Robert Levine analysed different cultures and their attitude towards time. He found that more economically developed countries like the USA, Germany, or Japan are fast-paced. In other words, they greatly value time since "time is money".

On the other hand, countries with less developed economies are slow-paced. Cultures such as the Middle East, South America, or Eastern Europe have a more relaxed attitude towards time. They are more family and socially oriented.

However, such differences may not always be as clear. For example, even though Japan has a fast-paced culture, they view social relationships as important.

Your group is doing a project on how different cultures view time. You are meeting to discuss the project. You may want to talk about:

- Hong Kong people's attitude towards time
- whether attitudes towards time are changing
- how to live a more slow-paced life
- anything else you think is important

PART B Individual Response

1. Are you often late for school?
2. Is being on time important to you?
3. How do you feel when your friends are late?
4. Do you prefer a fast-paced or a slow-paced lifestyle?
5. Is a fast-paced lifestyle healthy?
6. Do Hong Kong people have good work-life balance?
7. Is work-life balance important?
8. Do you agree that time is money?